BRITISH COUNCIL

English Online

LIVE25

Conditional 3

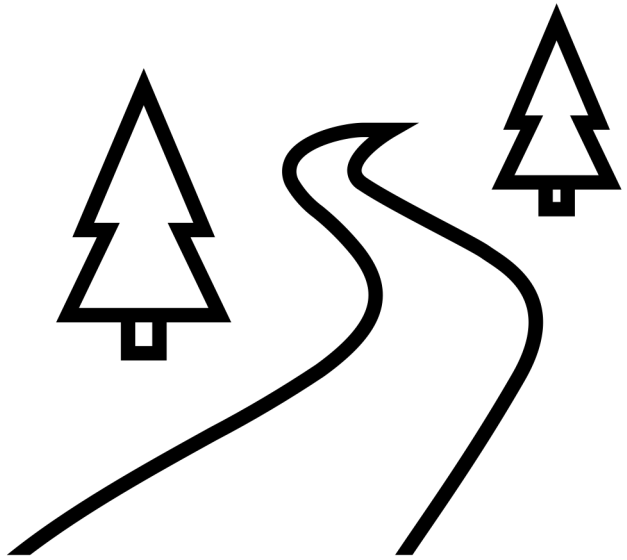
Introduction

Welcome to Live25!

- A new feature of English Online
- Free grammar presentations
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Please be on mute

You can keep your cams off



Lead-in

Do you know the past participle of these five verbs?

- choose
- go
- buy
- forget
- know



Meaning

We use the Third Conditional to talk about the past, as opposed to the First and Second Conditionals, which talk about the future. The Third Conditional speculates about past events that didn't happen and cannot be changed.

If I had heard my alarm clock, I would have woken up on time.

I did not hear my alarm clock, so I did not wake up on time. It is impossible to change.

Use

The third conditional can be used to make excuses:

If the traffic had been better, I would have got to work on time.

Or to express regret:

If I had known it was your birthday, I would have bought you a gift.

Or to express reproach:

If you had told me about the meeting, I would have come.

Form

If + subject + past perfect… , subject + would have + past participle

If I had woken up on time, *I would have caught the bus.*

Or the structure can be reversed:

I would have attended class *if I had caught the bus.*

Remember, we don't use a comma (,) when starting with the main 'would have' clause.

Question word + would + subject + have + past participle + if + subject + past perfect

What would you have learned *if you had attended class?*

We can also use had + subject + past participle:

Had I attended class, *I would have learned about the third conditional.*

Check your understanding

1. Does the third conditional refer to the future?
2. Did it happen?
3. Is it possible for it to happen?

Alternatives

We can replace would have with *could have* or *might have* when we are not so sure of the something happened.

If the weather had been better, we ***could have*** *had a picnic.*

If he had studied harder, he ***might have*** *passed the exam.*

Check your understanding

Match the meaning to the modal verb

Could have	A) criticize or give advice
Might have	B) show it was a possibility (but didn't happen)
Should have	C) show it was able to happen (but didn't)

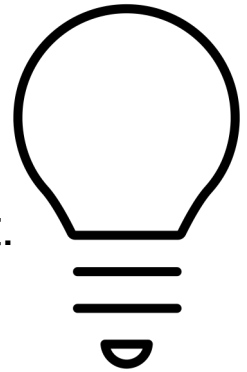
Key point: Differences in tense

We can also use the Third Conditional to reference the present:

If I had gone to bed early last night, *I wouldn't be tired right now.*

I didn't go to bed early (past). **I am tired now (present).**

So we can use would instead of would have when imagining how a change in a past situation would affect the present (also called a 'mixed conditional').



Grammar tip:

We use Third Conditional with **would have** for an imagined past situation and the different past result.
We use a Third Conditional with **would** for an imagined past situation and the different present result.

Grammar Checkout

Now try this! Find the mistakes:

1. If I had ate breakfast, I wouldn't be hungry right now.
2. I could have gone out, if it had been sunnier.
3. If you have listened to me, you wouldn’t had made that mistake!



Grammar Checkout - Answers

Now try this! Find the mistakes:

1. If I had eaten breakfast, I wouldn't be hungry right now.
2. I might have gone out if it had been sunnier.
3. If you had listened to me, you wouldn’t have made that mistake!



Thank you for attending this presentation!

Review the next few slides for lessons linked to this Live25 webinar.

https://learnenglish.britishcouncil.org/grammar/intermediate-to-upper-intermediate/conditionals-2

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Lesson: What to do

Pre-intermediate
Theme: Workplace skills
Lesson: Changing jobs

Intermediate
Theme: All about me
Lesson: The decision process

Upper intermediate
Theme: Storytelling
Lesson: Do you regret?

Advanced
Theme: Education and training
Lesson: Life skills

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Lesson: Questions, questions

Pre-intermediate
Theme: A new position
Lesson: Describing yourself

Intermediate
Theme: Meetings and negotiations
Lessons: Managing a meeting

Upper intermediate
Theme: Working with clients
Lesson: Your ideal company

Advanced
Theme: People and events
Lesson: Organising a client event